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Relationships

Have you ever been in a relationship? Who decided to create the relationship? What did you bring to it? What did you take from it? What value did your relationship create?

Because most of us have been in relationships, we tend to take them for granted, like fish within the water in which it swims. But we are wise to pay attention. Relationships are the threads with which we weave our families, communities, and associations. Relationships, unlike transactions, require making commitments to a shared future. Relationships rooted in commitment to a common purpose, what I call “civic relationships,” are also threads with which we weave organizations, movements, and democracy itself. Yet for the last fifty years, we’ve been engaging more in transactions than in relationships, especially civic relationships.¹ So if we are to renew our democracy, the foundation will be renewing our relationships with each other. In this chapter we begin learning how we can—and in more inclusive, equal, and authentic ways.

My Relational Challenge

Relationship building did not come naturally to me. I grew up in a relationally challenged home. My father, who struggled with the relational work his rabbinical calling required of him and was later diagnosed with paranoid schizophrenia, was emotionally unavailable to both my mother and me. Because of his difficulty keeping a post, I changed schools in the first, third, and fifth grades, each in a different location, with new classmates and teachers. My father could not teach me how to deal with bullies—or even how to throw a baseball without ridicule—so peer relationships were sources of anxiety for me. And I was a rabbi’s son in communities in which it seemed like Friday night was about football, not prayer, for everyone except me.

It was in the civil rights movement that I found my way to relationship building—civic relationship building. Even before I got to Mississippi,

it was clear that organizing, and my own safety, depended on others: SNCC organizers, my peers, local leadership, and members of the Black community in general. It was mind-bending to begin seeing white as threatening and Black as safe. But I was blessed with Hollis Watkins as a mentor. Hollis was twenty-two in chronological years, just two years older than I. But in organizer years he was far older than I could know.

Hollis grew up in Mississippi and in 1961, at nineteen, inspired by the Freedom Rides, he joined Bob Moses as an organizer in SNCC's first foray into Mississippi. In the three years since, he had been jailed multiple times, served time in the infamous penitentiary at Parchman, and comforted the families of persons murdered in the struggle. But he had also seen young people show the courage not only to challenge their elders but also to challenge Jim Crow itself and had earned a key leadership role in the Summer Project—even though he thought white students could be more trouble than they were worth.

All this made Hollis not harder, but wiser. He had also developed a gift for sharing his wisdom. On the second day of riding with him, I worked up the courage to ask how I, a Jewish white guy from Harvard, could connect with the people on whom I would depend, at times for my life. He stopped the car and said one word: "Respect." "Sure," I said a bit too quickly. "I have respect for everyone." "No," he said. "Respect is what you do, not what you have. First, listen, and hear; second, ask, and learn; third, show respect, and you will get it; and fourth, don't try to be anyone different from who you are. Be yourself." This turned out to be fundamental to every successful relationship I would build in my work, not only in Mississippi but also in my years with the farmworkers and, I'd like to think, with the students with whom I work with today.

I learned to build civic relationships in SNCC. It was our source of power. Critical of the flashy demonstrations favored by Dr. King, SNCC advocated long-term work in relationship with local people. One such example was organizing the Mississippi Freedom Democratic Party, locally rooted but coordinated at the district and state levels. Doing so required talking with people—lots of them—and under conditions far riskier for them than for me. Listening, asking questions, and learning really mattered. When I was assigned to Amite County, I was given a home by E. W. Steptoe and his family on his forty-acre farm about one mile from the Louisiana border. Mr. Steptoe was one of a band of courageous local leaders, including Medgar Evers, Amzie More, and others, who organized chapters of the NAACP in the

1950s and had lived to tell the tale—except for Evers, assassinated in 1963. Accompanying Mr. Steptoe to talk with people was very different from going on my own. New relationships were formed, connections made, and leaders identified. At times, relationships were built with the help of the pastors, deacons, or missionary society leaders in the churches. Other times, it was through local store or bar owners, like “Mama” Ayleen Quinn, who ran the Saturday-night juke joint in McComb and who seemed to know everyone. Sometimes it meant going door-to-door. But regardless of where or how or when it happened, relationship building was central to our organizing.

What Is a Relationship?

We all build relationships, and by building relationships we construct a shared future. When asked what it takes to build relationships, many point to trust, commonality, a shared purpose, and so forth. These factors are more likely to result from a relationship rather than motivate the formation of one. Relationships are motivated by differences, differences that can be exchanged (Figure 2.1): I have a resource you may need, and you have a resource I may need. This may sound cold unless we have a broader understanding of what can be a resource: understanding, empathy, courage, companionship, and collaboration. Needs may vary as well: a tennis partner, help with studies, someone to talk to, a chance at a job. If there’s no exchange, there’s no relationship—but exchange alone doesn’t make a relationship.

Let’s say you have had a great conversation with someone over coffee, but it’s time to go. Eager to continue the conversation, you pull out your calendar. “Why don’t we continue this next week?” “Err . . . I can’t,” you hear. “I have a project deadline on which I need to focus.” “Oh,” you say, “then how about the following week?” “Umm. I have some guests coming from out of town.” “Then how about next week?” “Why don’t I send you an email . . . ?”

What just happened? What was missing? A mutual decision to commit an hour of your time—your most valuable resource—to giving the relationship a chance: a chance to build a future, to acquire a past, to grow, to change, to become a resource itself.

Why would you risk committing your resources to an uncertain future? This is where values may come in, perhaps even not explicitly, because we may experience the emotional content of our values even when not articulated. This experience of shared values may motivate a person to take the

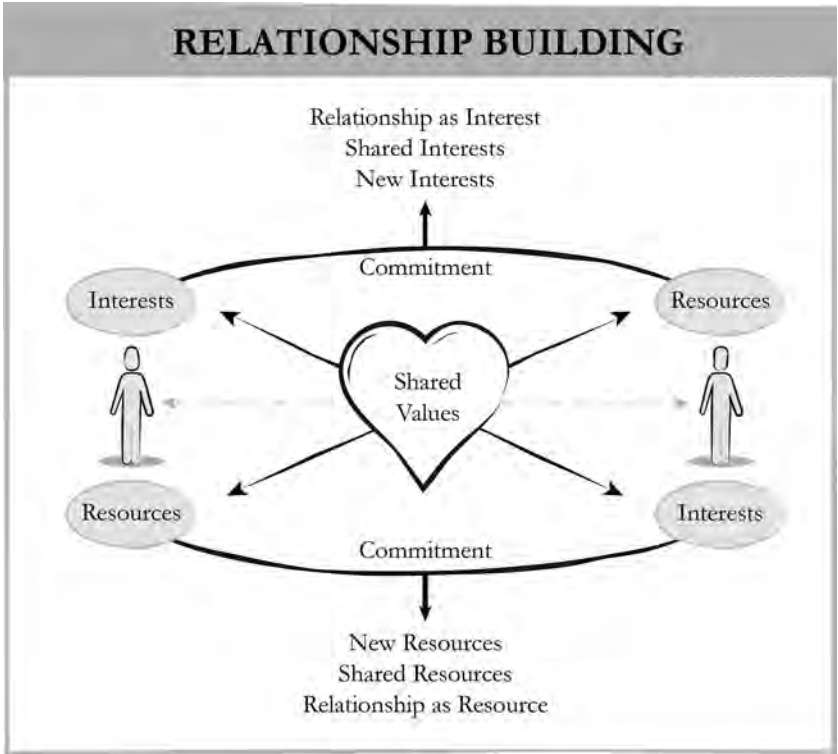


Figure 2.1 Relationship Building. *Source:* Steve Downer of the Difference

risk. If so, beginning a relationship takes courage, a leap of hope that trust may emerge later. Relationships, then, are about commonality and difference: commonality makes them possible; differences make them beneficial.

Relationships constitute the fabric of social life. It is through relationships that we construct ourselves, our communities, and our organizations.

Why Do Relationships Matter?

We all build relationships because humans are relational creatures. As long ago as the fifth century BCE, Aristotle spelled this out on one side of the world while Confucius spelled it out on the other. Although every culture abounds in wisdom about how to handle relationships, often distinguishing the instrumental from the authentic, the nature of relationships only came into

question in the West around the time of the Protestant Reformation, with a shift in how the individual was viewed within a society.² An individual's opportunity to choose relationships with intentionality rather than limit themselves to the relationships into which they were born—along with their familial, caste, tribal, racial, religious, and gender constraints; inequalities; and other cruelties—was surely a good thing, but it was also disorienting. This led to struggles over the relationship of individual and collective, especially in the bloody religious wars of the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries. Views of the individual shifted again as industrialization transformed a person's labor, and thus the person, into a commodity.³ In the nineteenth and twentieth centuries, both secular and religious movements continued to struggle with the right relationship of individual and community; some enhanced one's individual agency with collective agency in the form of democratic movements while others offered escape from the burdens of individual agency in collective submission to the will of a great leader, through authoritarian movements.⁴

Tocqueville, writing in the early nineteenth century in the context of his experience of revolution in his home country, linked equality with a radical individualism associated with the erosion of traditional authority. A focus on narrow self-interest could undermine governance on behalf of "self-interest properly understood," that is, "common interest." But he found promise in the associations he called America's "great free schools of democracy," writing,

Americans of all ages, all conditions, and all dispositions, constantly form associations. . . . Wherever, at the head of some new undertaking, you see the government in France, or a man of rank in England, in the United States you will be sure to find an association.⁵

Civic associations remained a major element of American social life until the 1970s and 1980s when, as political sociologist Theda Skocpol shows, membership in associations gave way to the management of organizations better at control than at representation.⁶ Older associations segregated by race, class, and gender went appropriately into the past. But because of political, economic, and technological choices, we have faced a whole new level of erosion in our relational fabric. Many imagine each person to be an isolated individual whose interests are best served through marketlike processes in which the successful survive and the unsuccessful disappear, all in the name of a purported well-being of all. Indeed, in much social science, the

rationality of relational affiliation itself was problematized as the collective action problem.⁷

We have come to interact with one another more in instrumental one-off transactions rather than in sustainable relational commitments. This radical recasting of each person as a unit of human capital, utility, or preference not only consigns civic relationships to the past; it also robs us of our humanity. Whereas we used to take relational communities for granted, we now take incentive-driven, utility-maximizing individuals for granted.⁸

The reality that modern societies face is the fact that political scientist Robert Putnam brought to the nation's attention in the 1990s: a radical erosion of the relational capacity he describes as "social capital." He identified the phenomenon and linked it to various deleterious outcomes but made little progress on what was driving it.⁹ One thing, however, is clear: a marketlike ideology of radical individualism, instrumental exchange, and competition does not help bring people together. This is especially true when this ideology's constituent parts can be amplified by using technology that makes it easier to share information and aggregate individual resources than to share commitment to one another to create collective capacity in pursuit of shared purpose. As one of my students put it, "I feel overconnected but undercommitted."

The fact that we begin with an argument that relationships matter reveals the depth of the challenge we face. Relationships do matter. Not only intimate relationships but also the far more fragile public, civic relationships on which the efficacy of democracy depends.

Why Do Civic Relationships Matter?

Civic relationships are the threads with which robust democracy is woven. Some relationships are private. We form them with our families, partners, and close friends, and they offer intimacy, love, and support. Other relationships are public, or civic. We form them with fellow citizens, colleagues, and collaborators, and they offer respect, commitment to shared purpose, and public trust. Organizing—and politics more generally—is about building civic relationships.¹⁰

As Tocqueville argued, civic relationships, or associations, are so important because they facilitate learning, solidarity, and self-governance.¹¹ They can be built with people not like us as well as with people like us, because they

are based on commitment to a common purpose, not on kinship, friendship, or childhood. This enables a broader understanding of common interests, greater creativity, and genuine inclusiveness.

Building civic relationships is intentional. Among those who first recognized their value was the Athenian political reformer Cleisthenes (d. 508 BCE). Looking for ways to establish each person's equality before the law, he realized that if one's participation in the *polis* depended on one's standing within one of the four traditional, and hierarchically governed, kinship-based tribes, this wasn't going to happen. So he persuaded the Athenians to replace these four kinship-based tribes with ten geographically based and democratically governed civic tribes. In other words, he replaced kinship with citizenship as a new form of political identity.¹²

Civic relationships, like citizenship, are based on commitment to shared purpose or values as the moral foundation of a political community. The ties we inherit, those based on to whom we are born, where, and under what circumstances, matter for our life chances. But we can exercise agency with respect to the conditions under which we share the right to participate in public life.

The distinction between private and public—or civic—relationships is important. We enjoy private relationships with friends, acquaintances, and others. But when we organize to pursue common goals, we need to make our associational roles explicit. When friends become officers of an organization to which we belong, they may experience tension due to the formalization—publicness—of what had been a private, informal relationship. Teachers must negotiate a way to be in relationship with their students, true both to their own way of interacting with others and to the formal public role for which they are responsible; similar issues arise for lawyers, doctors, social workers, ministers, and organizers. We can distinguish the social interactions appropriate in private relationships from interactions appropriate in public relationships. Failure to distinguish between the two can come at great personal cost to us and to those with whom we work.

In *Roots for Radicals*, community organizer Ed Chambers makes the useful distinction between being liked in our private lives and being respected in our public lives:

By acting publicly to be liked, people invariably violate their group or organization's self-interest, usually by failing to hold public power brokers accountable at critical moments. . . . What people need in public life is to

be respected, which is like, but different from, being liked. That is why it is crucial to learn to act for respect in public, to be disinterested in being liked there, to look for liking in the private realm. . . . Prophets, visionaries, and ordinary people who value justice and democracy can't be too concerned about being liked in the public realm, but they must insist on being respected there.¹³

Civic relationships are created by choices we make to link our own fate to that of another. Unlike momentary transactions, they sustain our engagement, succor us with support, and challenge us with growth. Some of our relationships—like our families—seem to be the result of chance. Other relationships—like our civic communities—are the result of choice. They only exist because the parties have chosen to give them life. In this way, we enable these relationships to shape our own lives, even as they shape the pathways along which we will live them.

Since we build civic relationships with intentionality, with whom do we build them? We can usefully distinguish between people like us and people not like us. Sociologist Mark Granovetter calls these strong ties and weak ties. Strong ties are homogeneous ties with people who are like us, and weak ties are heterogeneous, those with people unlike us.¹⁴ It is easier to build relationships with people like us, but civic association may require that we build relationships with people not like us but with whom we can find common purpose. Relationships with people like us can be very supportive but can also close in on themselves, isolating us in echo chambers and limiting our creativity. Relationships with people not like us may require more work but can open us to diverse sources of information, a rich variety of perspectives, and greater creativity.

Granovetter's insight is that strong ties may inhibit our capacity to organize. This is because they quickly create a closed-in, limited circle of people and resources. A lot of weak ties, in contrast, may enhance our organizing capacity. This is because they create broader networks of resources by opening the circle outward—an important way people find jobs. As an example, he shows how the fragmentation of residents of Boston's West End into intense ethnically, religiously, familial, or culturally bounded "strong ties" inhibited their ability to combine and mobilize resources to resist urban renewal. On the other hand, diverse communities with weak ties found it easier to collaborate with each other and secure outside sources of support. For some purposes, especially those we share with people like us, strong ties may be

very important. But for purposes that are broader and more inclusive, weak ties are the keys to success. Granovetter isn't arguing that strong ties are bad and weak ties are good—just that they are very different and contribute to common efforts in different ways.

Each of us has acquired values that inform the choices we make about specific interests. A resource is anything I can use to advance my interests. I may value good health, which gives me an interest in regular exercise, but I have a hard time sticking to it. You may be good at sticking to it but find the exercise boring. Despite other differences, we may both value good health enough to risk committing our time to building a public relationship with each other.

Commitment can turn a transactional exchange into a transformational relationship by giving it a future into which we can grow and a past from which we can learn. Relationships are beginnings, not endings. Unlike a contract that results from negotiations to protect our interests, relationships are open-ended, creating opportunity for our interests to grow, change, and develop. Our interactions may reveal interests of which we had not been aware: "Hmm . . . Before you asked me those questions, I didn't realize that I really wanted to be a doctor, but now . . ." We may discover common interests of which we were unaware: "After we started bowling together, we learned that we both like opera." Just as relationships can source new interests, they can also generate new resources: "Oh . . . you say I'm a good listener? I didn't know that." We may discover exchanges well beyond the original exchange: "I'll help you with your problem sets if you help me with my literature essay." And we may discover common resources: "Let's pool our funds to hire a tutor to work with both of us."

To the extent relationships become a shared resource, we develop a shared interest in doing the work to sustain them. This is why relational communities are capable of collaborative action of all kinds. Relationships among members are the foundation of any civic association. This can distinguish civic or political associations from civic or political firms that provide services to clients or market products to customers.

Relationship-Building Practice

Despite the importance of relational work, I didn't—nor did other SNCC volunteers—have any formal training in how to build relationships based on any theory of how to build them and why they worked or didn't. We followed,

watched, listened, and learned. It was only when I got to the farmworkers that I began to learn that organizing was not only a matter of earnest, patient, and persistent work with the local people but was also a discipline, a craft, a practice to be learned, trained in, and adapted.

Organizers begin with a search for leaders or potential leaders. An organizing project grows via the identification, recruitment, and development of leaders who, in turn, can develop more. This search begins with relational work. Where might you find potential leaders? If you begin with recognized community leaders, it can be hard to know who is actually leading and who just holds a title. You might also begin by talking with other members of the community whom you meet at public events, at group meetings, or through door-to-door canvassing. You may start by canvassing, especially in an electoral setting, and following up on leads from a meeting or a rally. The point is that you are looking for persons with whom to get started, especially those who show signs of leadership.

One-on-Ones

The basic organizing practice is the one-on-one meeting, an intentional conversation in which we share stories, learn of each other's values, explore each other's interests and resources, and decide whether to commit to working together—or at least to meeting a second time. Their primary purpose is to decide whether to invest in building a relationship with this person within which deeper engagement and more possibilities may develop. A one-on-one meeting is successful if it ends either with a commitment to a next step—perhaps only another one-on-one meeting—or a decision that it would not be wise to invest further. This tactic can be very useful for building robust relationships among people who might not otherwise have formed them and has come into wide use well beyond the field of organizing. It is the most widely practiced skill associated with community organizing.

I only understood the real power of the one-on-one in 1984, after I had left the United Farm Workers (UFW), when at an Industrial Areas Foundation training in San Antonio, I observed veteran organizer Ernesto Cortes model one. I thought the purpose of a one-on-one (or personal visit) was to get a person to commit to coming to a rally, signing a petition, holding a house meeting, or something similar. It could be quite transactional. Ernie turned his meeting into a moment of real connection, learning, and value creation.

He enabled a moment of real self-discovery for his partner by using probing questions, genuine attention, and useful, if challenging, feedback, a technique organizers call “agitation.” When well done, a one-on-one can enable each person to acquire an interest in sustaining the relationship itself, not simply as the means to some other end but as rooted in the experience of self-discovery, shared values, and the promise of new possibility, of hope.

One way we can discern values, as I discuss in the next chapter, is by sharing stories of self: those narrative moments in which we learned to care, which are often moments of hurt, and moments in which we learned to hope. Sharing these moments can enable the other person to get us in a way a resume, interview, or question-and-answer cannot. We grow up, we encounter challenges, large and small, we figure out what to do, and we learn from them. These are moments of challenge, choice, and outcome. So one of the most direct forms of exploration is to learn each other’s stories, focusing on choice points. Why did you go to school here rather than there? Why did you study this rather than that? Why did you decide to emigrate rather than remain at home? As we begin learning each other’s answers to these questions, we learn more about each other, what moves us, and what we can contribute. An organizer who can elicit another person’s story of self shows real interest, attention, and engagement that few of us experience in our daily interactions.

Similarly, a person who shares a story of self enables another to access their value sources in a real way. An organizer might begin with a simple version of their own story of self, just enough to give the other person some sense of who they are and why they want to talk with them, and then show interest in them by probing for their story of self. Most people will not find this offensive, but rather engaging. We all seem to be interested in people who are interested in us. Then you can share more about your own story, noting points of convergent value where you may find them. But this is only the beginning. To the extent that we can locate shared values within which to embed a potential relationship, the relationship may grow.

It is important to distinguish between a lead—someone who shows interest—and a recruit. A person is not a recruit until a relationship has been built that anchors their sustained engagement. Community leaders—religious leaders, labor leaders, parent leaders—can be very important, especially if you are trying to build an organization of organizations. Even if they are too busy, they may refer you to people within their network with leadership potential. This is how Fred Ross found Cesar Chavez in San Jose, based on a referral from the local priest. It can be more challenging if you’re

approaching a local leader or leaders who don't want any competition. There is a Mexican saying: "Entre menos burros, mas elotes," the fewer the donkeys, the more the corn. Sometimes we fool ourselves that we can co-opt community leaders into leadership roles in our organization when the reality is that they already have more than enough to do and are unlikely to drop everything and join our cause.

The challenge is to find good leads, so you don't use all your time on random contacts. When building political organizations in campaigns, we may start with people who have already volunteered. We can also go door-to-door in a neighborhood we need to organize until we find persons with whom we can have a one-on-one and, perhaps using house meetings, go from there. This can be especially important if you are trying to build an organization from scratch. By identifying potential community leaders—those who can hold a successful house meeting—you need not rely on existing organizations that may be resistant to change. That's how we found the people with whom to organize the Get Out the Vote campaign for Bobby Kennedy in East LA. In the 1983 mayoral election in San Diego, we also learned to target people identified as "always" voters, whom we could then recruit to take responsibility for turning out the "occasional" voters among their neighbors.

How do we begin a one-on-one (Figure 2.2)? First we must catch the attention of the other. If I call someone up to set up a meeting, it will help get their attention if I can say I was referred by someone they know. If I'm calling a potential volunteer on the phone, it will be important for me to use their name and explain how I got it. We may be related to a common institution, or across a room full of people, we may just make eye contact.

Once we have gotten the other's attention, we need to establish an interest in taking the time to have a conversation. I may mention, for example, how I was told they were interested in doing something about domestic violence and that's what I'd appreciate their advice on. Or I was told they are the key person from whom to get advice about what is really going on in the parish. Or since we happen to be working on the same project, maybe we should talk about how we can help each other. Be transparent about who you are, who you're working for, and why you want to have a conversation. "Hiding the ball" or withholding information can create serious trust issues that can undermine the whole thing.

There usually follows a period of exploration, of asking and answering each other's questions, of probing for areas of common interest, of testing whether the other has anything to contribute to us and whether we have anything to

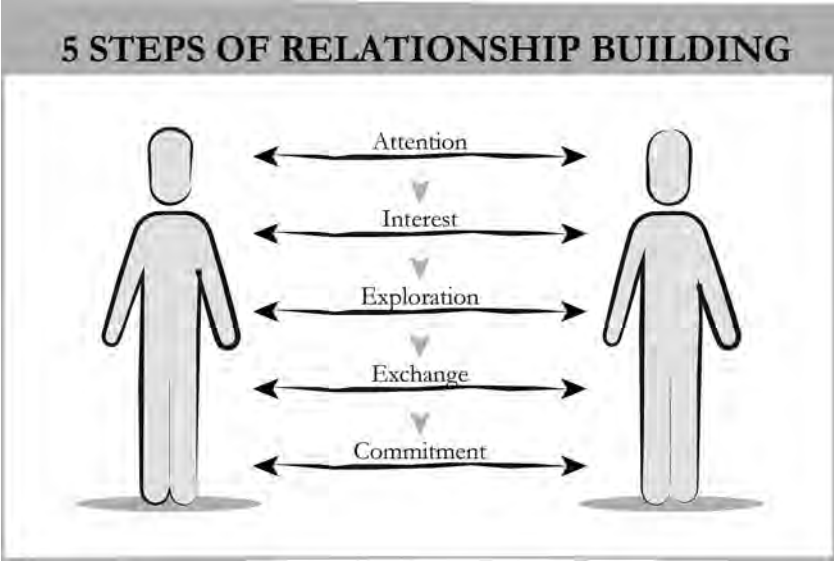


Figure 2.2 5 Steps of Relationship Building. *Source:* Steve Downer of the Difference

contribute to the other. The key here is learning to ask good questions, such as why a person has made the choices they have. This is where the story of self can be most useful.

As a result of our exploration, we may begin to make exchanges—not just in the future, but then and there within the conversation. We may turn out to be a good listener for someone who needs to be heard. We may find we are learning a great deal from the interaction. We may find we can challenge the other person in ways that may bring them new insight (“agitation”). We may find we can offer the other person some understanding, support, or recognition they find valuable. We may discover a basis for future exchanges—such as going to see a movie we both want to see, deciding to come to a meeting the other has told us about, taking responsibility to help pass out some leaflets, or just deciding to have another conversation.

Implicitly, one-on-ones explore three questions: Do I have resources in which you have an interest? Do you have resources in which I have an interest? Do we share values that may motivate us to work together that go beyond a single exchange or moment in pursuit of shared interests?

And if we’ve determined a basis may exist for a relationship, we may commit to meeting again and to continuing the conversation. We can turn

an exchange into a relationship by committing to each other. People often err by going right to a commitment without having first created a relational basis for it. We may identify shared values and experience fruitful exchanges, but only commitment can transform an exchange, even a promising one, into a relationship.

Although one-on-ones are not the only way in which organizers build relationships, they are fundamental to the craft. They can also be used to get to scale. We can hold numerous one-on-ones to recruit a fresh network of individuals whom we can organize to work together to create a mass meeting of hundreds of interested people. We can hold one-on-ones to identify leaders who can launch committees in multiple locations. We can meet one-on-one with representatives of diverse groups who join to create a coalition to pursue their common interests.

One example of the use of one-on-ones was when my friend and former colleague Jim Drake came to town to organize the Greater Boston Interfaith Organization (GBIO), which at present links sixty dues-paying member churches, synagogues, mosques, community development corporations, unions, and other groups and represents over 107,000 people.¹⁵ Jim devoted his first two *years* of work almost entirely to one-on-one meetings—a practice that has achieved almost ritual quality in an organization that operates across many traditional boundaries. When GBIO launched, it was at a 1,700-person public meeting, the most diverse in Boston memory. On May 27, 2008, GBIO, which deserves major credit for health-care reform in Massachusetts, celebrated its tenth anniversary with an assembly of some 4,000 people drawn from all these communities, attended by the mayor of Boston, the Speaker of the Massachusetts House of Representatives, and the governor of the state.¹⁶ This example offers some insight into how the challenges of associating across lines of race, class, culture, generation, and ethnicity can be surmounted. It took work on a firm ground of respect . . . and many, many one-on-one meetings.

House Meetings

One-on-one meetings can lead to house meetings, where the host invites a network of their acquaintances to attend, some of whom will commit to hosting their own house meetings, activating social networks that weave

their way through every community. House meetings are designed to make use of these networks.

In the UFW, our basic training was in house meeting organizing, a method Fred Ross devised when organizing the Community Service Organization (CSO) in East LA in the late 1940s. Unlike in Chicago, where Ross's employer, Saul Alinsky, had developed a form of community organizing by organizing organizations, in East LA, there were few organizations to be organized. Even the Roman Catholic Church viewed the Latino community as more appropriately served by missions than conventional parishes. So Ross reached out to a with a small number of local leaders who in 1947 had failed in attempt to elect Edward Roybal as the first Latino to serve on the Los Angeles City Council since it was formed inn 1889. They worked with Ross to organize house meetings to expand their relational networks to build the organization. In the 1949 election they succeeded not only in electing Roybal by organizing an historic Latino voter registration and turnout effort. They also succeeded in launching the Community Service Organization which was to become the Latino civic association that developed the leadership, organized the local chapters, and, by acting on a statewide, play a significant role in California public life.¹⁷ Four years later Cesar Chavez was not only trained in this approach but was in fact recruited in a house meeting—a key moment in his own story.¹⁸

House meetings work because they begin with a civic relationship between an organizer and a person who commits to becoming a host. The host invites fifty people they know—not only close friends and family—to come to their house in a few days for a one- or two-hour meeting. The host convenes the meeting, explains its purpose, and invites guests to share stories, thoughts, and feelings about their challenges, sources of hope, and places of connection. They then discuss pathways to action. They are asked not only to commit to an action program but also to host their own house meeting within a few days. New relationships are built from old ones, new leaders (hosts) can emerge, and scaling up begins.

I was introduced to my first house meeting—a meeting in which my lack of Spanish drove me to do what I had to do to achieve fluency—in Bakersfield by Cesar's cousin Manuel Chavez. Manuel's method of training consisted of not showing up and expecting you to sink or swim. It wasn't until I worked directly with Cesar in a six-week campaign in Earlimart early in 1968 that I really got it. You did as many one-on-one meetings

as you could to find a person who would commit to hosting a meeting. This required being careful not to box yourself into a corner by avoiding people you thought might not be interested. Or by recruiting the wrong person. The organizer would follow through, make reminders, and show up to make a presentation, engage the attendees, make asks, and recruit as many people as possible to host their own meetings, creating a cascade of meetings through which more people could be recruited, not unlike the well-known Tupperware parties.

We used this approach in the Howard Dean presidential primary campaign in New Hampshire, in which we asked each potential host to make a list of fifty people with whom they were acquainted. This helped ensure more heterogeneous connections. It turned out almost everyone could, with the organizers' help, make such a list. The organizer then coached the person on how to get the people there successfully: practicing a phone call, an in-person ask, and so on. In this way, we quickly met with a large number of people in conversational settings and identified a corps of potential leaders from among the house meeting hosts.

In the 1987 Pelosi for Congress campaign in San Francisco, our team of six organizers held eighty-seven house meetings attended by six hundred people in just three weeks. In addition to being asked to host another meeting, attendees were asked to volunteer on a phone bank. At the end of the house meeting drive, the eighty-seven hosts and another fifty very active volunteers were invited to a meeting at which they were asked to become precinct leaders. In this way, four weeks into the campaign, we had recruited proven leaders for 110 of the 150 precincts we needed to organize to cover the entire congressional district. Each also had its own corps of volunteers with whom to work.

This approach is so useful because you can start almost from scratch in any setting and identify potential leaders from among house meeting hosts. The host, not the organizer, does the recruiting, coached by the organizer. The organizer turns informal private and public relationships into the formal public relationships with which to build an organization. And if done well, it can grow geometrically. During the first Obama campaign, by October 2007, organizers in South Carolina had held some four hundred house meetings, attended by some four thousand people. This became the foundation for the deployment of fifteen thousand Election Day volunteers—most of them active politically for the first time.¹⁹

Emergency Meetings

On occasion, we simply do not have the time or the numbers to begin as above. The less time we have, the more organizers we need; the more time we have, the fewer organizers we need. An emergency meeting can be one way to mobilize within limited time, but to do so in a more relational way. This is often the case in last-minute electoral campaigns. In the 1986 US Senate campaign of Senator Alan Cranston, we had to organize a Get Out the Vote in some twelve hundred precincts in African American and Latino districts of South-Central LA, East LA, San Diego, San Jose, and Oakland. We recruited fifty organizers who accepted responsibility for recruiting fifteen precinct leaders each. Since we had very little time—the whole campaign was done in five weeks—we built on what we had learned in the San Diego mayoral campaign: we got registered voter lists for each precinct that were coded as to who “always” voted, who “occasionally” voted, and who “never” voted. The organizers called the “always” voters in their turf to recruit them for an emergency meeting that afternoon or evening at campaign headquarters. From among those who attended, the organizers recruited precinct leaders who agreed to contact the “occasional” voters in their precinct and to take the day off work on Election Day to help us get them out to vote. We turned out an additional 160,000 voters this way. Cranston won by 110,000 votes.

Relationships are the glue of any organizing effort. And like any other relationship, they require ongoing maintenance work. Old relationships need to be renewed and new relationships developed. If this ongoing work is not done—and if the relationships unravel—it becomes harder and harder to accomplish the tasks that must be accomplished. We also may remain ignorant of who the people are that make up our organizations and what they have to contribute. In the absence of solid relationships, the kinds of political difficulties and factions with which we are all familiar develop, undermining our collective capacity.

Building Relationships Online

Although the tactics we’ve looked at so far vary in setting and in scale, what they all have in common is that they develop direct relationships among people we hope to involve in the work of the organization. These tactics do not

rely on flyers, phone calls, or email, because relationships are about commitment and co-creation, as well as information. Initially, online media was used mainly for sharing information, not for building committed relationships. Similarly, the idea that technology alone can enable people to self-organize doesn't work. Meetup, for example, one of the key platforms the Dean campaign used for organizing in 2004, facilitated thousands of meetings between people looking for others with similar interests but suffered from a very high mortality rate because it offered no training, structure, or coaching that could enable these new groups to succeed.

A more promising route for relationship building is at the intersection of online and offline organizing. Tech has long been used to make it far easier for people who want to become involved to do so—for them to become leads and find leads. In the summer of 2007, some one hundred thousand potential volunteers had signed up for the Obama campaign online, but the campaign did not yet have the capacity to engage them. Once this capacity was built, however, these records became a very important way to grow the movement. Similarly, use of online tech can put tools in the hands of people who are motivated to use them to find others who are interested in them, to reach out to others who may be interested, and, as in the phone bank operations during the campaign, to reach out to individuals in other states whom they could contact by phone. The relative ease with which information can be shared greatly facilitates reporting, coordination, analysis, and, in general, transparency, as when the Obama campaign decided to share the VAN, or Democratic Party Voter Activation List—what had until then been closely guarded voter file information—with volunteer leadership teams.²⁰

More recently, especially in the wake of COVID-19, we all got a crash course in how to use Zoom to initiate, cultivate, and develop committed relationships. Visual technology like this enables people to see and interact with each other in real time so that they can build relationships and share learning, motivation, and interaction at a very low cost and in a way that goes far beyond what was possible in writing or over the phone. The closer we can get to face-to-face visual interaction, the more we can harness the power of new tech to the work we do through relationship building. I experienced this potential when I took my practice-based organizing class online in 2010. It has grown annually to about 140 students from some thirty countries and a team of seven teaching fellows who each work with some twenty students, creating an online learning community through one-on-one meetings,

establishing shared purposes, adopting group norms, and so forth. As with good organizing practice, these sessions include the scaffolding, coaching, and peer-learning necessary for sustained engagement.²¹

In the summer of 2018, I led an organizing workshop in Silicon Valley with young people eager to apply their technical skills to solving social problems. One challenge that became evident during this workshop was that many of the participants seemed to be thinking of human beings as users—individual customers whom one must incentivize or disincentivize to do the right thing and not the wrong thing—rather than people whom one can engage in learning, reflection, or moral and political judgment. Tim Berners-Lee, the inventor of the World Wide Web, once commented to me that while machines can make decisions based on this or that algorithm. But only human beings could exercise the judgment to make choices.

A second challenge is to distinguish information sharing—or awareness facilitated by digital communication—from relationship building. Digital information sharing is usually anonymous, unidirectional, individual, and almost always devoid of commitment. Relationship building, on the other hand, is based on making commitments to other people with whom I share a common purpose.

A third challenge was enabling workshop participants to recognize the difference between *aggregating* individual resources and *organizing* collective capacity. Mobilizing individuals to send an email, contribute, or show up at a rally without building relationships among them creates no collective capacity. It spends down resources we have rather than generating new resources. This approach also realizes none of the benefits of association, which include learning, solidarity, collaboration, and leadership development. It substitutes mobilizing for organizing, as well documented by sociologist Zeynep Tufekci in *Twitter and Teargas* and political scientist Hahrie Han in *How Organizations Develop Activists*.

Because social media dramatically reduced the cost of sharing information in real time, many now decide to skip organizing and go straight to mobilizing. They count on crisis events to generate reactions, choices made by individuals who command the media, and the ability to generate big numbers of clicks, even if the impact is no greater than that of counting sheep in the clouds—and not as beautiful.²² Unless we build the organizational capacity—lateral committed relationships, decision-making venues, and leadership structures—to do the mobilizing, not only will the resources dry

up, but mobilization will turn out to have been nothing more than tactics in search of a strategy.

Happily, we have begun to learn to distinguish between carpenters and tools. The best hammer in the world won't build a house. It takes a skilled carpenter, with a vision of what a house can look like, command of the craft of building houses, and a readiness to use new tools to get the job done better. Effective organizers are distinguished by the craft of turning the new energy and connections made possible by digital tools into a successful organization or movement. We all build relationships, but excellence depends on doing the work to master the craft that can become an art.

Conclusion

How leaders practice relationship-building in any given campaign depends on their role in the overall campaign strategy. In the examples I've discussed here, these skills were used to build an organization from scratch (as with the farmworkers), create a campaign organization (Pelosi, Dean, Obama), and build an organization of organizations (GBIO). In an electoral setting, even if the organization is abandoned after the election is over, relational organizers may have created quite a bit of civic capital that can be of value in subsequent campaigns. Most organizations employ some combination of relational organizing through individuals, networks, and organizations. But the claim that "we can't do relational organizing because it will take too long, and our situation is urgent" is belied by many of the examples I've cited here. Urgency can motivate going deep very fast, or it can be used to justify remaining shallow to invest in other priorities.

We can begin with brand-new relationships based on leads recruited at tables, street corners, sign-ups at rallies, or other gatherings. We can begin by drawing people in through relational networks of which they are already part. Sometimes networks are recruited from old organizations that act as incubators for a new effort. This was the role of many of the southern Black churches and colleges in the civil rights movement, which some scholars referred to as "indigenous mobilizing structures."²³ We can also build relationships with leaders of existing organizations, bringing them into relationship with each other to make a new organization possible. This makes use of organizational resources that already exist, but it also requires accommodating the new organization to meet the interests of existing organizational

leaders. This was Alinsky's approach and is that of the Greater Boston Interfaith Organization.

Regardless of the chosen approach, organizers create collective capacity through the purposeful formation of civic relationships to enable democracy to work. I focused on relational tactics first because the devil is in the details. Far too often, organizing campaigns fall short and then say organizing didn't work, when it failed because they didn't invest resources—time, people, and money—in the training needed to achieve excellence. What really matters is not the amount of time in weeks, months, or years but rather the value placed on relational organizing, the quality of the initial training, and a commitment to sustained coaching.

In sum, relationships are the threads with which community—and constituency—are woven. We form them to create the social context within which we engage in numerous social transactions every day. They construct the context within which we articulate our individual and collective narratives, develop our creative strategy, situate our collective action, and build structures that enable us to work with others. This is why the instrumentalization of our relational worlds is so deeply disorienting and, at the same time, creates the necessity for their reconstruction. This is what organizing does. And it is what makes democracy work—or not.